

Geographies of Wellbeing in Poland (Urban-Rural, Regions, and Cities)

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1 Wellbeing

The outcome of interest in the proposed study is multidimensional human wellbeing or flourishing. Two key dimensions are happiness or life satisfaction¹ and freedom (agency/autonomy)²

Happiness is now recognized as a development goal in addition to GDP and the UN Resolution (A/RES/65/309) "Happiness: towards a holistic approach to development" stating that "the pursuit of happiness is a fundamental human goal" and "recognizing that the gross domestic product indicator [GDP] by nature was not designed to and does not adequately reflect the happiness and well-being of people" (<https://docs.un.org/en/A/RES/65/309>)³

Freedom (agency/autonomy) is a human right: "freedom for the realization of one's human potential" The Universal Declaration of Human Rights (art. 26, 29). Freedom is an end-in-itself (Okulicz-Kozaryn 2014), as recognized by Fromm (2013, 2012, 1992, 1964, 1944, [1941] 1994) and Sen (2000).

So far the wellbeing geographies field has had mostly international focus across countries, with only few recent studies focusing on specific countries.

Now the time is right for such a study in Poland. Poland as of 2026 is not very different from Western Europe anymore, a quite developed country. Indeed, Polish PCGDP PPP⁴ is now about the same as in Japan, and Polish minimum wage of 31 PLN or 8.15 USD (as of 2026) is higher than US minimum wage at 7.25 USD.

It was not like that before, however. I remember about 10 years ago I gave a talk on happiness in Warsaw, and students didn't seem to see a need to care about happiness. Traditional topics like income and consumption seemed more important.

Happiness is increasingly relevant as Poland has been a developing country and now transitioning into a developed country so quality of life and wellbeing increasingly matter over economic/survival basics such as income and unemployment in the past. Poland used to be quite poor where focus rightly so was on survival and economic growth. As Poland has experienced economic miracle over

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I thank XXX. All mistakes are mine.

¹We use the terms interchangeably as is the usual practice in the social indicators literature, but specifically we mean global cognitive evaluation of life as whole rather than momentary and fleeting affective happiness.

²Specifically we mean so called "freedom to", not "freedom from" (Okulicz-Kozaryn 2014). Poles are "free from": live in a free country, have no coercion, and are free from restrictions and impediments. But are they "free to"? Are Poles actually able to choose, control and direct one's own life? Not so much (Okulicz-Kozaryn 2015).

³Also see report promoting wellbeing a human development measure by Nobel prize laureates Sen and Stiglitz (Stiglitz et al. 2009).

⁴Per Capita Gross Domestic Product Purchasing Power Parity adjusted.

past several years⁵, now it's time to focus on wellbeing. For visualization of the changing values from survival to wellbeing along with the economic growth see figure 1.

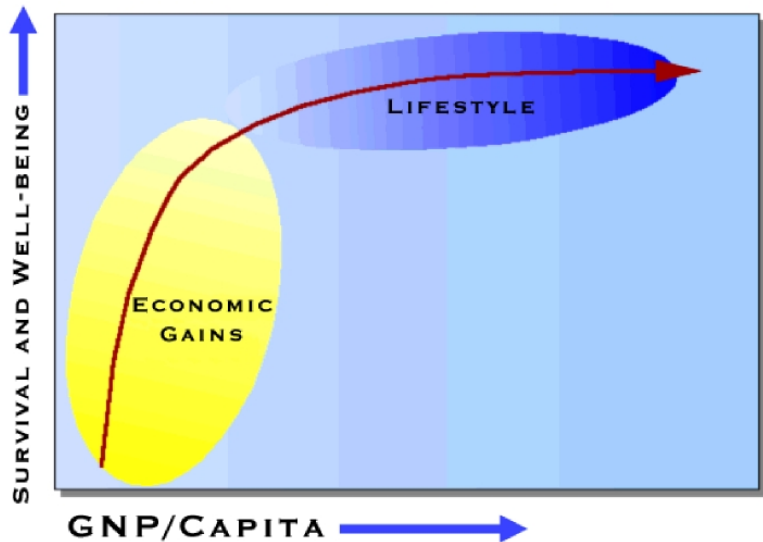


Figure 1: From survival to wellbeing as economic growth increases (Inglehart 1997).

2 Geographies: Urban-Rural, Regions, and Cities

guess cp here lit from my papers esp recent ones: [make sure i caover everything i have in hypotheses!!!] guess moree qol livability stuff and shrinking gorwing

Poland is a large country, 9th both in terms of area and population in Europe⁶ And yet we know little about geography of wellbeing in Poland and lack a dedicated study. Hence, I propose this study to fill the gap.

Poland is a diverse country in terms of its urban-rural, regional, and city geographies. Urban-rural is not a binary, but a gradient—we will use several steps to measure this gradient. Urban-rural gradient matters a great deal, much more than most realize. Indeed, it is difficult to overestimate its importance, the key point is that it is not only built environment, but a way of life (Wirth 1938).

Weckroth and Kemppainen (2021) is a closely related study—they analyze SWB by urban-rural using ESS in Europe—we will also use ESS among other datasets but focus on Poland and adding more recent waves and more wellbeing indicators. Knies (2026) is another close ESS study—it uses multiple indicators but only one wave 6, and like other research does not focus on Poland. We will use all 12 waves.⁷ There are no studies on urban-rural freedom gradient, not just in Poland but anywhere—ours is the first.⁸

Next we turn to regions. Regions are an useful level of analysis as there are great differences within countries and across regions and Poland is no exception. There are SWB studies across regions, but not focusing on Poland (e.g., Okulicz-Kozaryn 2011, Ballas and Rijnks 2023, Ziogas et al. 2023, 2020). Similarly regarding quality of life and wellebing across regions and cities—the studies focus on cross-country patterns, not Poland, and tend to use older datasets (Okulicz-Kozaryn and Valente 2019, Okulicz-Kozaryn 2013). Poland has 17 voivodeships or so called NUTS2 level regions. We will investigate relationship between objective development measures such as income and subjective measures (SWB). There are also interesting population dynamics at NUTS2 level, for instance, while

⁵For instance Warszawski Index Gieldowy (WIG) has increased about 120% over past 5 years.

⁶See unstats.un.org and <https://population.un.org>.

⁷Ivanovic et al. (2022) is yet another ESS urban-rural study, but again only 2 waves and no focus on Poland. Vaznonienė and Jarašiūnaitė-Fedosejeva (2019) is interesting ESS study in a sense that it does focus on one country and discusses country specific intricacies like us, but it is Lithuania. Okulicz-Kozaryn and Valente (2021) is a major recent study using WVS, but as most research it focuses on cross-country patterns, not Poland.

⁸Yamagishi et al. (2012) studies urban-rural freedom but in very different way from us—they show that urbanites are more likely to chose extravagant pens than rural folks

Mazovia (where Warsaw is located) has been growing, many other regions have been stable or shrinking. We will investigate the effect of population change on wellbeing—as we know that population dynamics are highly correlated with SWB (Okulicz-Kozaryn et al. 2024).

Finally, we have data representative of Bialystok, Gdansk, Cracow, and Warsaw with domain satisfactions (life, place, personal, and financial), and various quality of life indicators regarding amenities and disamenities such as availability of public services and community problems. We will investigate how these differ across the 4 cities. Specifically, large Warsaw (and perhaps Cracow) is likely to differ from small Bialystok. Warsaw stands out as not only the largest city, but also possibly as primate one (disproportionately larger and more influential than any other city).⁹

Last but not least there are several related Polish studies worth mentioning. The closest first. Sompolska-Rzechuła and Kurdyś-Kujawska (2020) is quite close, but uses different data: Polish Social Diagnosis dataset and does not control for SWB predictors.

Vazonienė and Wojewódzka-Wiewiórska (2021) uses ESS and urban-rural SWB like us, but focuses on Lithuania and Poland and waves 4 and 9 only, uses only 3 urbanicity categories and does not control for SWB predictors. Wojewódzka-Wiewiórska and Dudek (2023) is the same just waves 2 and 8.

Tobiasz-Adamczyk and Zawisza (2017)—there are regions, urban-rural and social connection and loneliness, but it is about elderly and health. Stangierska et al. (2022) has green v not green urban areas and quality of life, but it is across Warsaw neighborhood only and the sample size is 381 persons only. Sompolska-Rzechuła and Kurdyś-Kujawska (2021) uses Polish Social Diagnosis dataset and examines SWB, but only separately—what are the predictors of SWB in urban v rural—it is different from our study and does not overlap with our hypotheses.

And there are several outliers. Churski and Perdał (2022) has very fine geographical resolution of 380 units across Poland, but they do not study SWB, but related objective indicators such as jobs. Weziak-Białowolska et al. (2025) is one of the thousands of the studies by Mr VanderWeele et al, this time in Poland, but there is no geography here. Wkeziak-Białowolska (2016) uses the same flash barometer 366 that we will use, but does not focus on Poland and instead on all European cities.

Hence, overall we know very little about wellbeing geographies in Poland and hence we turn to our yet un-answered hypotheses.

3 Research questions and hypotheses

This research is about geography of wellbeing in Poland (urban-rural gradient, regions, and cities). SWB stands for Subjective Wellbeing, specifically multidimensional wellbeing.

Hypotheses:

H_1 Cities have lower SWB than rural areas with the largest drop occurring for the largest places. [WVS, ESS]

H_{1a} Some social groups such as working-age adults and higher social classes have higher SWB in cities v rural areas. [WVS, ESS]

H_{1b} Over time, from 1989 to 2012, the SWB gap between cities and rural places has increased. [WVS]

H_2 More remote, less populated and lower density regions have higher SWB than more central, more populated and higher density regions. [ESS, FB539]

H_{2a} Regions that experienced population growth will have higher SWB than flat or shrinking regions. [ESS, FB539]

H_{2b} Across regions correlation between objective quality of life measures such as income with SWB measures will be moderate only at <0.5 thus revealing inadequacy of paying attention only to traditional progress/development measures such as income. [ESS, FB539]

H_{2c} Urban-rural happiness gradient across regions will be relatively stable, i.e., larger places having higher SWB than smaller places.

⁹At $> 3m$ Warsaw metro is larger than Katowice metro at about 2.5m and third Karkow metro at 1.5m. While Katowice metro is not half or less of Warsaw metro as “the law of the primate city” would indicate (see discussion in Berry and Okulicz-Kozaryn 2012), it is only due to the location of Katowice in regional industrial cluster (Gornoslaski Okręg Przemysłowy (GOP)), Katowice city itself is much smaller than city of Warsaw .28k v 1.9m. Maybe Warsaw is not such clear primate as Cairo is (Mikhael et al. 2024), but it could be similar in its primate status to Bogota (Okulicz-Kozaryn et al. 2026).

[ESS, FB539] H_3 The relationship between quality of life (local amenities and disamenities) and domain satisfactions (life, place, personal, and financial) will differ across Bialystok, Gdansk, Cracow, and Warsaw. [FB366,419]

4 Data and Measurement

The goal is to do a comprehensive study of Polish geography of happiness, hence we use multiple datasets, each having its own strengths: World Values Survey (WVS), European Social Survey (ESS), and Flash Barometers (FB) for regions and cities.

WVS has a usual SWB item: “All things considered, how satisfied are you with your life as a whole these days?” on scale 1-10. Such SWB measures tend to be reasonably valid and reliable (Diener 2009, ch. 5), WVS allows us to examine the geographies of wellbeing over time, interesting research question because Poland has evolved greatly especially in 90s, 00s and 10s, and we have data going back to 1989. We have about 4k observations, about 1k per wave. We use waves 1989, 1997, 2005, and 2012.¹⁰ For the 1997, 2005, and 2012 waves we have 8 rural-urban categories -2k, 2-5k, 5-10k, 10-20k, 20-50k, 50-100k, 100-500k, and 500k-. Also the important advantage of WVS is that urbanicity is interviewer recorded, and thus more objective than subjective respondent self-reports.¹¹

Freedom is measured in WVS.¹² Validity and reliability of the measure seem fine and the variable has been used successfully in the literature (e.g., Verme 2009, Inglehart et al. 2008, Veenhoven 2000, Okulicz-Kozaryn 2014).

ESS has a whole battery of wellbeing items measuring functionings and vitality. Preliminary analyses using ESS 1-6 cumulative file already had over 10k observations for Poland.¹³ We will use ESS items such as those in wave 6 on functioning “enthusiastic about what you are doing,” and vitality “had lot of energy.”¹⁴ ESS urbanicity is measured with: a big city, suburbs or outskirts of big city, town or small city, country village, farm or home in countryside.

FB539 (2024) has 5.2k observations and is representative of 17 regions (voivodeships) so called NUTS2 regions, and it has a usual SWB question similar to WVS.¹⁵

FB366,419 are representative of 4 Polish cities: Bialystok, Gdansk, Cracow, and Warsaw. The sample size is about 2000 observations, and again we have a usual SWB question like in WVS.

5 Models

We will mostly just use ordinary least squares (OLS).¹⁶ Still, for robustness/sensitivity checks for the key models we will use multinomial logit (as the ordinal logit tends to fail proportional odds assumption). As another robustness/sensitivity check we are considering machine learning models such as gradient boosting models Oparina et al. (2025), specifically XGBoost <https://xgboost.readthedocs.io>.

¹⁰In 1989 we only have information about voivodeships, 49 at a time, but urbanicity can be inferred from this information indirectly, and directly proximity to a major city.

¹¹For instance respondents may not know well whether they live in a 20k or 30k place.

¹²“Some people feel they have completely free choice and control over their lives, while other people feel that what they do has no real effect on what happens to them. Please use this scale where 1 means 'none at all' and 10 means 'a great deal' to indicate how much freedom of choice and control you feel you have over the way your life turns out.”

¹³The data will be updated upto wave 12 that will be available in 2027.

¹⁴See overview at <https://www.europeansocialsurvey.org/findings/europeans-wellbeing/measuring-wellbeing>. Round 6 wellbeing items: <https://europeansocialsurvey.org/sites/default/files/2026-01/ESS12-wellbeing-module-design-template.pdf> see Table 1: Items from the wellbeing module grouped by the dimension of wellbeing they relate to. We also will use new wave 12 that will be available in 2027 and will contain a wellbeing module. See <https://europeansocialsurvey.org/sites/default/files/2026-01/ESS12-wellbeing-module-design-template.pdf>.

¹⁵We may also use the earlier flash barometers: #497 (2021), #472 (2018), #427 (2015), #356 (2012) depending on how strong robust the latest wave results are.

¹⁶Although OLS assumes cardinality of the outcome variable, and SWB measures are technically ordinal, OLS is an appropriate estimation method. Ferrer-i-Carbonell and Frijters (2004) has shown that OLS results are substantially the same as those from discrete models, and OLS has become the default method in happiness research (Blanchflower and Oswald 2011). Theoretically, while there is still debate about the cardinality of SWB, there are strong arguments to treat it as a cardinal variable (Ng 1996, 1997, 2011).

We will use a usual set of controls such as those in the literature, for instance for life satisfaction: Berry and Okulicz-Kozaryn (2009), Okulicz-Kozaryn (2010); and for freedom: ??

A key robustness/sensitivity check will specification curve analysis (SCA) (Simonsohn et al. 2020). And, related, we will pay extra attention to the choice of control variables and avoid overcontrol bias:

What we really need, to identify/estimate $X \rightarrow Y$, is to control for other determinants of Y that are also antecedents of X (so, $W \rightarrow X$). If we include controls where the relationship goes the other way ($X \rightarrow W$), we will exacerbate bias in our estimate of $X \rightarrow Y$. (The relevant term for that situation is 'overcontrol bias') (Bartram et al. 2024, p. 5).

To examine geographic patterns among regions we will use Moran's I and Local Indicators of Spatial Association (LISA) (Anselin 1995).¹⁷

6 Significance, Policy, and Practice

The proposed research aims to contribute to the literature, produce new knowledge. But it also has practical implications. First, as stated in the introduction, the time has come for Poles to focus on wellbeing as opposed to just survival. We have higher incomes close to Western Europe, modernized the infrastructure, and have booming economy. The focus on survival and economy can now shift towards wellbeing and flourishing. This is called evidence-based pursuit of happiness (Veenhoven 2012).¹⁸ The proposed study will find out which Parts of Poland are happy and for whom, which social groups, e.g., age and social class. And this should help Poles to become happier.

SWB can and should be used for public policy and administration (Diener 2009). SWB can serve as a "yardstick" (Veenhoven 1988) as arguably the ultimate outcome of public policy and administration is SWB. "If you can't measure it, you can't improve it"—how governments can improve lives of people if we don't track wellbeing? I plan to change that starting locally. I plan to reach out to Polish government to see how the study can be used in practice. I plan to start with Wielkopolska voivodeship, where I will be physically carrying out the study. And other regional governments may be involved as I will be carrying out the study. Likewise some city governments may be involved as the study will use data representative of 4 cities.

Again, as elaborated in the introduction, the time has come for wellbeing in Poland—and this project should significantly contribute. There will be several papers out of this project and through further research mentoring and leadership many more. See for details in the application form under "Działania mentoringowe." **see if that's where it fits**

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¹⁷We may do some multilevel modelling (MLM) at NUTS2 level as in Weckroth and Kemppainen (2021) but focusing on Poland. Yet MLM is problematic with only 17 U/As at Level 2—if we use it, results will be postponed to appendix. We may use Small Area Estimation (Moretti and Ahmed 2024).

¹⁸There is a psychological nuance here—one should not focus fully on the pursuit of happiness and chase it or value it intensely (Mauss et al. 2011, Gruber et al. 2011), neither be concerned about it and judge it (Zerwas et al. 2024)—it may backfire. Rather, one needs to know what is important for wellbeing from the academic literature, like the proposed study, and include this information in everyday decision-making. For instance, humans should buy experience such as travel and time with others, not things such as conspicuous consumption items (Okulicz-Kozaryn and Tursi 2015, Veblen 2005a,b, Thoreau 1995 [1854]).

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